Scenes from the Climate Era

DAVID FINNIGAN



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Foreword

EAMON FLACK

CLIMATE CHANGE IS A DRAMATURGICAL PROBLEM.

One of the unexpected paradoxes of being a big-brained species is that we have to imagine reality before we know how to live with it. I could find myself in Tjoritja (the West MacDonnell ranges) in Arrernte country in the remote Northern Territory of Australia and I'd see a desert landscape that would kill me in a day if I ran out of food and water. Arrente people on the other hand see a place of sustenance and extensive life. The Arrernte reality is thorougly imagined, but it isn't imaginary. It lives in complex webs of story and knowledge that describe not just sources of food and water but a whole way of life. It's very real. Just not to me.

We face a similar situation with climate change. It's all around us, it's very real, but we struggle to imagine its realities. And without some vision of its realities then our ability to live - both in the sense of sheer survival and the sense of meaningful shared existence - is in serious doubt.

We don't just have a science and tech problem with climate change, we have a dramaturgical problem.

If you don't know what dramaturgy is, that's ok. Ask ten dramaturgs and you'll get ten different answers. Dictionaries say it's "the art and technique of dramatic construction". It's basically what we do in theatre to answer the question, What's the story here and how do we tell it?

So, what's the story with climate change and how do we tell it? How do we imagine the reality of climate change?

Here's the tricky part. We don't know yet. Different kinds of stories come to life in, and for, different realities. The stories of the Arrernte people have complex multi-part forms that echo the realities of life in the desert. Streaming television was great for a pandemic, giving us glimpses of other times and places from the inert nightly hell of our lockdown couches. The Mass served the Catholic Church pretty well for about a thousand years, with its cunning form of revolving stories told within the body of a single repeated, and repeatedly enforced, story.

The vast majority of our stories today have evolved specifically in and for the realities of liberal carbon-burning capitalism. It is a storyworld that is entirely normalised to us, like water is to fish. And it's almost entirely blind to climate change. Why and how?

Let's gets dramaturgical for a moment and note some things about the storyworld we, fishlike, swim about in.

In the centuries between Shakespeare and Ibsen most of our stories moved from being set in big halls or outdoors into small rooms. Most of our stories today are about people in rooms. That makes sense: ever since industrial capitalism our centres of power have moved from royal courts to backrooms, from battlefields to boardrooms; our working lives have moved from fields and communal spaces to private rooms. Most of modern life is characterised by people in rooms.

But here's the thing: climate change doesn't give a shit about people in rooms.

Here's another example: most of our stories today are underpinned by some ideas first formulated two and a half thousand years ago by Aristotle in his study of tragedy: that good plots are focused on the actions and fate of an individual (the "protagonist") in a unified time and place.

Climate change doesn't give a shit about individual actions, and it obliterates the human-scale Aristotelian "unities" of time and place.

If we're going to begin to imagine the reality we are living in, we need to start thinking about new kinds of stories. We need to get used to different scales of time and place. We need stories that are bigger than people in rooms. The dramaturgical problem is the same as real world problem: how do we put the non-human world into our human frame of reality?

Fortunately there is nothing inevitable or innate about this capitalist carbon-burning storyworld of ours. The are other possibilities. Arrernte stories use very different ideas of time and place, and they cross easily into the non-human world of animals, plants, weather. Epic forms like The Mahabharata extend beyond individual story outcomes and span large arcs of time and place.

There are of course already new stories being created that show the way when it comes to climate change. I know of two that have left me unable to see the world the way I used to. Richard Powers's novel The Overstory is one. The other is David Finnigan's Scenes from the Climate Era.

David's play does what climate change does: it diminishes the focus on the individual and obliterates the unities of time and place. It shatters the famous rules of story that were invented by ancient tragedy and misappropriated to grease the wheels of modern capitalism. And yet I would argue that the play is very much a new kind of ancient tragedy. Like a tragedy it is made of information rather than character, and like a tragedy its subject is life, eros, the quickening energy of survival and ongoingness. And like a tragedy it is about the discovery by its "protagonist" - in this case not an individual but a whole species - that life as they know it is already over. It maps out a vision of life in the climate era that is a lot like the ancient eye of fate: a vision of many times and places at once, all bound by a sort of inexorable oncoming force, all struggling to speak to each other,

desperate to catch the signals across time and space, to catch a vision of the path of fate before it's too late. And like a tragedy all its hard-won knowledge may be too late, there may already be no way out.

But it's most like a tragedy in this: the provocation of David's play is to urge us away from the tragic outcome.

The play premiered at Belvoir St Theatre in the middle of this year (2023). There was no set, just some chairs and a table. Five actors never left the stage and never changed costume. The whole thing was done with as minimal a footprint as possible. The result was a kind of aesthetic of scarcity, much like the world the climate era may bring us to. As the scenes progressed sand (in fact breadcrumbs) sometimes fell from the ceiling, as though a crack had opened up in the world. At the end the sand fell in huge cascades. It was a production which rightly put the emphasis on the information, on the fragmented form, on the sense of a coming eruption. What came to the fore was how funny the play is, how potent its statements of fact are, how powerful it is to hear the truth named in public.

I won't pretend it's an easy play to pull off, or that David has once and for all solved the dramaturgical problem of climate change. Scenes from the Climate Era feels like early versions of a computer operating system: it is a proof of concept, and we will get better at this with subsequent passes. But David has pulled off the great feat of version 1.0. His play asks you to let go of a whole lot of old ideas about how stories should be, and freefall into a new idea of reality.

It's time to dramaturg the fuck out of the climate era.

Eamon Flack
July 2023

EAMON FLACK IS THE ARTISTIC DIRECTOR OF BELVOIR ST THEATRE. HE IS AN AWARD-WINNING DIRECTOR, WRITER AND DRAMATURG.



Author's notes

DAVID FINIGAN

I've been making theatre with climate researchers for nearly 20 years. Before that, I grew up surrounded by environmental scientists (my dad is a climate researcher specialising in turbulence and windflow). In the whole time I've been following the climate conversation, I've never seen anything like the last five years. Everything is shifting, fast, in good ways and bad, and the pace is dizzying.

People been talking about climate change since the 1970s. For most of those five decades, the conversation has been stuck in a loop. Politicians, businesses, activists, scientists, climate deniers, all saying the same things, while the only thing changing is the concentration of carbon dioxide in the atmosphere.

About five years ago, everything changed.

in science conferences and journals, climate scientists began debating solutions than would have been unacceptable just five years earlier. Fossil fuel lobbyists and pundits shifted tactics from direct climate denial to the language of greenwashing and delay.

In the political sphere, governments and businesses started signing up (sincerely or not) to 'Net Zero by 2050' pledges. There was a new wave of climate activism, from Extinction Rebellion to the school strikes, both larger and more extreme than anything that had come before.

And all over the world, climate impacts hit harder and faster than any model predicted.

Before five years ago, I felt like my writing was trying to direct people's attention to the conversations happening in climate science. After that shift, those conversations were suddenly everywhere. In the last five years, my work has shifted to an attempt to document the flood of climate conversations taking place everywhere: in meeting rooms, on social media, over dinner tables, in bus shelters, car radios and on dancefloors.

I was raised to live in a world that was a certain way. That world no longer exists. Truthfully, it was gone before any of us were born. We were educated for a life on a planet that was already gone, and we didn't know it. Now we're starting to take stock of the world we actually live in, and it means rethinking everything.

I wrote this play as an attempt to capture some of the thousands of stories unfolding in this space over the last few years. This is a selection of some of the things shared with me by colleagues working in research, in climate policy, in the mining industry, on the frontlines of activism, and many other sectors.

This play is a snapshot of some of the contours of this new world. And it's also an invitation. Because we can't navigate this new world by ourselves. So we're inviting you here for a conversation, to help us figure out: what is this new planet we've found ourselves on? And how are we going to get through it?

An incomplete list of people whose work I've drawn on in telling these stories:

Anab Jain, Honor Harger, Ketan Joshi, Naomi Oreskes, Issa Lopez, Peter Brannen, Alex Steffen, Ben Yeoh, Andreas Malm, Anna Emmelin, Brian Walker, Beth Fulton, Roger Bradbury, Anne-Marie Grisogono, Victor Steffensen, Greg Mullins, Bernie Krause, Clive Hamilton, Kim Stanley Robinson, James Bradley, Ed Yong, Thom Van Dooren, Rebecca Huntley, Tyson Yunkaporta, Cassie Lynch, Michael-Shawn Fletcher, Dan Hill, Holly Jean Buck, James Vaccaro, Kimberley Jutze, Lydia Hascott, Elizabeth Kolpert, David Wallace-Wells, Gaia Vince, Amitav Ghosh, Derrick Jensen, Jamie McCaughey, Sabrina Smith, and DJ Sabrina The Teenage DJ's incredible 2020 album 'Charmed'.

An even more incomplete list of the people who've helped me make this, through readings and good advice:

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Secondly, thanks to those people who helped shape this script from its earliest form to where it is now: Rebecca Giggs (always), Annette Mees, Adam Hadley, Jordan Prosser, Chris Finnigan, Nathan Harrison, Rachel Roberts, Bec Massey, Nikki Kennedy, David Shaw, Jordan Prosser, Lloyd Allison-Young, Eleanor White, Yolande Norris, Jean Mostyn, Elly Speer, Tom Wright, Bridget Balodis, Chris Thorpe and Tessa de Josselin.

Finally, thanks to the two scientists who've shaped what I do: my dad and his best friend, John Finnigan and Will Steffen.

David Finnigan
June 2023

Credits and acknowledgements

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Script Design New Best Friend

Cover Image Brett Boardman

First produced in June 2023 by Belvoir St Theatre, Sydney.

Director Carissa Licciardello

Set & Lighting Designer Nick Schlieper

Costume Designer Ella Butler

Composer & Sound Designer David Bergman

Assistant Director Clement Rukundo

Dramaturg Vaishnavi Suryaprakash

Observing Director Rikiah Lizarraga

Stage Manager Luke McGettigan

Assistant Stage Manager Christopher Starnawski

Production Manager Ren Kenward

With Harriet Gordon-Anderson, Abbie-Lee Lewis, Brandon McClelland, vAriadne Sgourgos, Charles Wu

Supported by Oranges & Sardines, Patty Akopiantz & Justin Punch

Scenes from the Climate Era



Contents

11 A difficult conversation

13 Beginner's guide

15 Scientists discuss a climate model

17 Bushfires '93

18 Three field recordings

19 Kyoto protocols

21 The last plane flight you ever took

22 A vigil

24 Post-show discussion

25 Focus group

28 Climate therapy

29 New reef

31 Budj Bim

32 A nightclub

34 Nub par: waves on sand

38 Banks and net zero

40 X-shredder mouse

42 Rice fields

43 Pipeline attacks

45 Backtail was heavy

46 Hope is the enemy

48 Evac Bingo

54 Snapshots

56 Post-everything

BONUS SCENES!

58 Living through extinction

59 Getting home safely

60 Interludes

61 The end of earth science

63 Shooting a wolf

64 Fossil fuel paramilitaries

65 First fire

66 Shark fin

67 Tearing up dams

68 Antarctic seawalls

70 Radiant bucks

71 Hair tournament

Hey!

So this is the order of scenes presented in the first Belvoir run, but this show was designed so that each production could add in / switch out scenes according to context and needs. The bonus scenes are all there to be folded in if you like.

You'll notice that this version is tailored for a Sydney / New South Wales context, but there's flexibility to alter settings where appropriate.

The one hard limit is that this piece should run no longer than 80 minutes (no interval), and preferably closer to 70. If we can't land it in 80 mins, we've gone badly wrong somewhere. Be ruthless!

Otherwise, it's all up for grabs, I'm open to chats.

Good luck have fun!

A difficult conversation

- A small kitchen, after dinner. A and B are washing up dishes.

A So do you want to talk about... what we were discussing?

B In light of?

A I just want to restart the conversation.

B Okay, what do I feel? Truthfully, I can see us being really good parents. Actually, I think you'd be great, you'd be so sweet all the time and I would be, I guess, the strict one. But in terms of setting out to…

A To get pregnant.

B Yeah, in terms of that. What am I thinking? Look, here it is. I just found out this week that paper bags are worse than plastic.

A How do you mean?

B Well it's about upstream vs downstream impact. A plastic bag is very easy to make, it doesn't take much energy. But then it sticks around in the environment for fifty thousand years or fifty million years - I forget which one.

A And it chokes turtles.

B Yeah, the turtles think it's a jellyfish and they choke on it. But a paper bag… it biodegrades really quickly and it goes straight back into mulch or dirt or whatever. But all the upstream costs… it takes like fifty times as much energy to make. And you've got to chop down trees to make it.

A So plastic's better than paper?

B I think it depends. If you care about turtles choking and microplastic bits in our body, then plastic's bad. But for global warming, paper's worse.

A What if you care about both?

B I don't know. But getting pregnant is, like, the worst possible thing you can do, right? It blows everything else out of the water. You stop driving, stop flying, stop eating meat, use a canvas bag for 50 years, and then you have a kid and it all gets wiped out.

A But they're not your emissions, they're someone else's. You can't put having a child in the same category as using a plastic bag.

B Why not? If you made the choice, why not?

A But you could raise a baby to be part of the solution, not part of the problem.

B Look, if we had an accident and it was a question of whether or not to terminate, that would be different. But to actively decide to get pregnant...?

A You want to, though. I don't want to put words in your mouth - but I really feel like you want to do this. And you're scared. Which, me too. But if we don't do it, I think you'll regret it.

B I'll regret it, for sure. But would I regret it more if we did it?

Beginner's guide

A Hi everyone, welcome. So this is the show. Zero to 'should we have a child in an age of climate ruin' in less than ten seconds, which has got to be some kind of record.

But we gotta figure, this is what you came for. You book for a show with the word 'climate' in the title, you're not messing around. So let's not waste time, let's go for the throat here.

When you walked in you were given an envelope. Inside that envelope is a single lentil.

Opens an envelope to demonstrate.

When you leave the theatre tonight, take a walk through the city, and when you see an SUV - a Ford Ranger, a Toyoto HiLux, any big unnecessary 4 wheel drive - stop, and unscrew the valve of the tyre. Inside, there's a pin that will release the air if it's pushed down.

Put that lentil on the pin and screw the cap back on. The tyre will be fully deflated after about an hour.

You can leave a note on the windscreen - something like, Hey, don't take it personally, it's not you, it's your car.

But if this feels too complicated, you don't have to leave a note, you don't have to mess around with lentils. Just take a key and run it along the paintwork. Ten seconds and two thousand dollars worth of damage.

If fifty people vandalise four cars each, every night for a month, that's six thousand SUVs. And then watch them start disappearing from the streets.

You see, politics isn't about voting in elections or winning debates - it's about having fun.

Anna Emmelin is a social scientist at the Stockholm Resilience Centre. She says that people go through three stages when they're getting to grips with climate change.

Stage 1 - denial. The world is transforming, but it's big, it's scary, it's too much to comprehend. So you don't accept it, you don't believe it's real. Maybe intellectually you know it's happening, but deep down in your gut, you can't believe it. And so you're paralysed.

But at a point, it finally sinks in. So then you move to stage 2 - solutions. You get energised, you search for ways to stop the problem, fix the problem, make it go away.

But sooner or later, you hit a wall - these solutions suddenly don't feel meaningful. That's stage 3 - grief, anger, despair.

On the other side of stage 3, Anna says, that's where you find hope.

Denial. Solutions. Grief. Hope.

Let's go.

MUSIC: Brockhampton - Boogie (instrumental)

A dances like a maniac. Strips off the suit bit by bit until they're in shorts and a singlet - then lowers the music, keeps it playing quietly behind them.

Scientists discuss a climate model

- It's 1981, 42 years ago. It's a green room in a TV studio, there's two scientists there.

B Okay, so you sit down, you've got the thing clipped to your lapel -

A A lapel mic.

B Right, and the cameras are rolling - and they turn to you and ask you. What do you say?

A I'm going to say I'm not convinced.

B You're going to say they're lying?

A I'm not going to say they're lying. I'm going to say I'm not convinced.

B You're not convinced about the Greenhouse Effect?

A No, the Greenhouse Effect is real, we know the climate changes. We know that CO2 traps heat in the atmosphere. More CO2, more heat, that's not controversial.

B And we know CO2 is rising.

A We know that it's risen. It might still be rising, it might have stopped. What I'm not convinced by is this whole idea of predicting the climate in fifty years on a computer. It's tech gone crazy.

B These are our friends.

A They're our colleagues. And I've got to be honest. That's our job. And speaking honestly, the whole thing is shaky.

B Their model says that within 200 years it could be five degrees hotter. The ice caps will just melt. Are you sure that's wrong? Because if you're not sure, you can't just go on TV and dismiss it.

A Of course I'm not sure. Look, these computer models could be right, and they could be wrong. But how can we know? They go talk to the atmosphere people and they ask, 'how does the atmosphere respond if you add more carbon?' Then they turn that into code and put it in their program. Then they talk to the ocean people and they ask, 'how does the ocean respond when it gets hotter?' Then they ask the forestry people, 'what happens with all that methane under the ice in Siberia?' They get all these numbers from all these different people and they throw it one computer program. The maths is loose. The whole thing is loose.

B Everyone who contributed to this project is an expert.

A Absolutely, they're all experts. But they're trying to put biology, chemistry, geology, meteorology, oceanography, into one computer model. And they don't have the computing power to actually run the program, so they simplify it. They take all these equations about atmospheric turbulence and ocean currents and they reduce them into a few lines of code. And then the computer program spits out a number saying the Earth's going to heat up five degrees next century. How do we know if it's right or wrong? We can't test it.

B You want to wait around and find out?

A No I don't. Of course I don't.

B Well what are you going to say?

A What can I say? I'm not trying to throw them under the bus, but I have to be honest. I'll say, okay, this is serious stuff, we should be looking at it very closely, there are some very good researchers behind this work - but based on the modelling I've seen so far, I'm not convinced.

Bushfires ‘93

\- It’s 1994, Sydney.

A Last year things were a bit off.

Normally it’s pretty straightforward. We do controlled burns through the cold months. Rain in November means it’s humid through til late January. Plants absorb moisture, they’re less likely to ignite, you’re usually safe. Not much winter rain and a warm spring, then you’re likely to get fires, starting in Queensland then shifting south. You watch for the cicadas, the christmas beetles, the bogong moths. When the banksia leaves turn yellow and die, that means the soil’s drying out. When you see ants swarm, it’s gonna piss down.

Someone said the original inhabitants used to do four or five burns in a year. First the boxwood, then the gum trees, then sand-ridge and stringybark country. Everything timed to the week so nothing would burn except what they wanted. We don’t have that kind of precision, but we get by.

But last year, 1993, things just went a bit off-kilter. Firefronts moving quicker than you’d think, spot fires in times and places you wouldn’t expect. Nothing drastic, just not quite right.

Then it rained in November and we relaxed.

Then - early January. The Howes Valley fire jumps the Hawkesbury and heads straight for the northern suburbs. Lane Cove National Park starts burning. There’s an outbreak at Macquarie University. And then it kicks off everywhere: the Blue Mountains, Central Coast, Sutherland, Warringah on the Northern Beaches, Ku-ring-gai Chase National Park, Elanora Heights, Gosford. Out of nowhere, and it just escalated.

No-one saw it coming. There are old blokes who’d been fighting fires fifty years - they’ve seen everything, and they didn’t pick it. One of them said, there’s something new here.

I said mate, it’s just a bad year. Roll of the dice, we won’t always get it right.

He said, I don’t know. I think something’s changed. And we’d better figure out what, quickly, or we’re in real trouble.

Three field recordings

A This is 2003, twenty years ago. The Elwha River, upstate Oregon. Recorded. You can hear the river. You can hear frogs, ravens, there are owls calling. Eagles, otters, wolves. And that low sound, that rumble - that's a mountain lion.

AUDIO: A field recording of a a busy North American ecosystem - the sound of a river, the sound of birds, owls, foxes, the low rumble of a mountain lion.

\- The same spot, 2023.

AUDIO: A similar field recording, but quieter. The river is less audible, but still dense with bird cries.

\- 2043.

AUDIO: A similar field recording, but even quieter. Perhaps the sound of traffic in the distance. The river is less audible, just the sound of insects and maybe a stray bird call, nothing else.

Kyoto protocols

\- It's 1997, a journalist and a lawyer in a newspaper office in Canberra.

A 'Dramatic scenes this week in the final hours of the climate negotiations in Kyoto, Japan.'

B That's good.

A You like that? That's the opener. 'This year, COP3, the focus for the talks was to agree on a 'Kyoto protocol' which outlines rules for how each country needs to reduce its emissions.'

B This all sounds fine. Is this what your editor's worried about?

A No, it's this bit. 'Talks begin in Kyoto in mid-November. Australian Environment Minister Senator Robert Hill remains quiet.' (skims over the next few lines) Negotiations drag on. The conference is scheduled to finish on Wednesday 10 December.

5pm Wednesday, no agreement.

6pm, 7pm, nothing.

8, 9, 10pm, the clock hits midnight, the conference is over. The delegates stay where they are and keep pushing.

Finally, 1am, a breakthrough. A deal is on the table. No disagreement.

The chairman of the negotiations reads out the finalised agreement line by line one last time. Everyone gets ready to sign.

At that moment, 1.42am, Robert Hill stands up and says, "We need to include a special exemption so Australia can keep emitting greenhouse gases. If we don't get that loophole in the agreement, Australia walks away and you don't get a consensus."

(reading) 'Following this interjection, the Australia loophole was inserted into the treaty, concluding Senator Hill and Prime Minister Howard's campaign to sabotage the treaty -'

B Okay, stop there. You can't say that.

A Which bit?

B You can't say 'Howard and Hill sabotage the treaty.' That's defamation.

A They planted a bomb in the talks, and they blew it up in everyone's faces. There's a word for it, and it's sabotage.

B When you phrase it like that, you're basically accusing them of corruption. If you publish this, you'll have a letter from their lawyers tomorrow morning.

A So what can I say?

B I'm not telling you what you can say, I'm telling you what you can't say - and you can't say, 'John Howard fucked us as a favour to his mates at Rio Tinto -'

A Where his nephew's getting a job as head of government relations.

B You can't say, 'John Howard fucked us as a favour to his mates at Rio -'

A Hang on, I'm writing it down. We can't say, 'John Howard fucked us...'

B 'John Howard fucked us as a favour to his mates at Rio Tinto, where his nephew's getting a job as head of government relations.' You can't say it. Think of something else.

The last plane flight you ever took

Vox pops.

- The last plane flight I ever took, I think was… July 2034? It was the turbulence that did it for me. Turns out more heat in the atmosphere means more unstable weather. More side to side turbulence, more big up and down bumps. That last ten years just got worse and worse. I remember one flight I nearly knocked my teeth out against the seat in front of me. Then the next flight, we started shaking suddenly and the flight attendant got thrown sideways into my seat. After that I said no, that's enough, I can't do this any more.

- My last plane flight? Ages ago, god, I think it must have been... December 2038, that's right. I hadn't flown for five years or maybe more by that point. Then my baby nephew was born, and it was a tough birth, my sister wasn't doing well, and I thought, I just need to be there. It's an emergency, it's worth it. I told my friends and they were like, that's a ton of carbon, they acted like I'd killed a puppy. But if it's life and death, yeah, I'd do it again.

- Sometime around 2040, maybe? Wasn't a big decision. Just easier to get a train, or a ship if you're going overseas. I never liked planes, I don't miss them.

- 2043. Yeah I remember it. The middle of '43, there were those bombings across Europe. 10 airports in the space of a week. Three hundred people dead on the tarmac at Heathrow. I had a flight coming up, and I said, fuck it, I'm not letting terrorists dictate my behaviour. But I was so stressed, takeoff to landing, I thought I was going to die. That was it for me.

- Me? I don't know, I never got on a plane again after covid.

A vigil

- It's 2027. A shipping container in the Botanical Gardens with glass tanks on all the walls.

AUDIO: Sound of a croaking frog.

A This morning he started calling. I didn't know what it was, to begin with. It's been more than a decade and he hasn't made a sound. And then this morning he just… called out.

This shipping container has been converted into a little frog habitat. And just one frog lives here. One silver fringe-limbed tree frog. And there's me, every day, keeping vigil.

When an animal species goes extinct, we call the last survivor an endling. Like Martha, the last Passenger Pigeon, died 1914. Or Benjamin the Thylacine, 1936. Lonesome George the Pinta Island tortoise, 2012. George the Golden Snail, 2019.

There are two remaining Northern White Rhinos: Najin and Fatu. Both female, neither pregnant. Eventually, one of them will be the last one. And then there'll be no more.

The silver fringe-limbed tree frog, we barely knew it existed before it went extinct in the wild. The species had just received a scientific name in 2014. Then that year, a fungal infection wiped out the whole population in Central America. We managed to save seven individuals and bring them here. One by one, they passed away.

This is the last one. My little nephew named him Smiley. And now I sit with him and keep him clean and fed. And there's not much else I can do. Except wait.

These creatures, they're not coming back. They've been on the planet for millions of years, and soon they'll be gone forever. Whatever else we do, we can't undo that.

Sometimes I think that we've made the whole earth into a hospice. It's too late to save these creatures. The most we can do is make them as comfortable as possible on their way out of the world.

So maybe caring is like a final act of contrition?

I've been looking after Smiley for more than a decade. In that whole time, he's never made a sound. But this morning, for the first time, he started calling.

AUDIO: Frog croak.

He's calling for a mate. And on this entire planet, there isn't a mate for him.

Post-show discussion

- It's 2023, it's tomorrow morning, a phone call from Newtown to French's Forest.

A and B are on the phone.

A Hey, can I talk to you about something?

B Yeah, what is it?

A It's... sorry, this is hard to say. About last night.

B Oh, right. Yeah, I know what you mean. I'm sorry.

A You're sorry?

B Yeah, I was out of line. Look, shows like that. Like I said, it's not what I'd choose to go see. Not that I think climate change is fake or anything, it's just - I do a big day at work, I want to go out and see something fun, something with some singing and dancing, not like, fucking, 'the last dying frog' or whatever. But look, you organised the tickets, you planned this whole night, and I was rude about it, and yeah. I'm really sorry.

A Okay. Thanks, but that's not what I... What I wanted to say was, last night I didn't think I was having an... but today I think, yeah, I actually am having an outbreak. Look, I've got herpes, and you should probably get tested.

Focus group

- It's 2021, a community hall in Mudgee, New South Wales.

A is hosting a focus group with B, C and D.

A Hi everyone, thanks for taking time today. If you haven't done a focus group before, it's basically just a conversation. I'm a social scientist. I'm going to ask you some questions, give you some statements, and I just want you to respond with whatever you feel. First of all: how big is the Australian fossil fuel industry? And I mean, what percentage of Australians work in mining or in fossil fuels?

B Um... maybe 15%?

D I don't know. Yeah, 15%, that sounds right.

A What if I told you that fewer than 1% of Australians work in mining? And that number is falling. Does that sound credible? Does that sound right to you?

D No, it sounds wrong.

B I believe it, but also, who cares?

A How do you mean?

B Okay well you're probably here shilling for renewable energy, so obviously you're going to have all your stats ready to go. But you're missing the point. I don't care if it's 1% or 50%, when we talk about fossil fuel jobs, we're not just talking about the guys down the mine, we're talking about everyone else in those communities.

A Like who?

B Like cafe owners, hairdressers, mechanics, cleaners - their wages are paid by fossil fuel workers. They would lose their jobs and their businesses if fossil fuels left town.

A And what industries do you work in?

B I'm a teacher.

D I'm a nurse at the hospital.

C Retired, full-time grandparent.

A Okay, so here's another statement: there are more jobs today in health and education than in fossil fuels. Does that sound credible?

B Again, it's probably true, but it doesn't matter.

A Why not?

B Because the mining sector creates wealth. You know, as opposed to service industries.

A Do you agree?

D I don't know. But yeah, I guess. I mean, nursing costs money. Without mining and the taxes they pay, we probably wouldn't have nurses or hospitals.

B That's right. Even if they don't employ a lot of people in the actual mines, it's highly skilled work, it pays well, it keeps the lights on for a lot of Australians.

C I just think we can't keep going like this. I think we're leaving this country in a real mess for the next generation.

A Okay so here's another statement: 30% of Australia's energy needs are currently supplied by renewables, and that will soon be 50%. Does that sound credible?

B Look, you want us to say it, so I'll say it: we're going to move to renewables. We know that, we're not stupid. It's a question of timing.

C My son-in-law put solar on their place, and they're not paying anything now -

B Yeah it's great for houses and buildings - my school has solar - but it's no good for manufacturing.

A So you would like more renewables?

C Well it depends. I want a solar panel for our place, I think they're great. But when they talk about putting wind farms all over the country, then no, I'd prefer the coal.

A How do you mean?

C I do wildlife rescue, I foster injured animals. I used to have a wedge-tailed eagle that I took into schools with me and give talks.

D That's right - what was his name? You brought him in to our class.

C Nathan. Nathan the wedgie, kids love him. Look, have you ever been up close to a wind turbine? They look like big pinwheels from a distance, don't they? But you get close up, those blades are spinning 200 kilometres an hour at the tip. A bird can't dodge that, they don't have a chance. You do a bird count around a wind farm, see for yourself - every one of those turbines kills thousands of birds a year.

A So you think the cost of wind farms to wildlife outweighs the benefit to the environment?

C You want to talk about environmental benefits - I think if you give kids an opportunity to see a native bird close up, and see how beautiful they are, and experience that, that's how you engage them with the environment. What you don't do is say, 'to protect the environment we're gonna put up these bird slicers that chop birds to pieces and bats to pieces'. What sort of message is that? And meanwhile we're not talking about the elephant in the room, which is overpopulation.

A So you would rather solar than wind farms -

C I would rather coal than wind farms. I'm not saying coal is great, but I think it's not black and white.

Instant snap to another part of the stage, another time, another place, another world.

- I wake up at 6am and check the forecast.

And then instantly we're back in the focus group like this never happened.

C You talk to people around here, the one thing everyone has is an environmental ethic.

B That's right, we were raised by parents who gave a damn. I tell you what, and I don't mean to criticise you personally, but I think a lot of the people proposing this stuff, environmentalists in Sydney or Melbourne or wherever, their carbon footprints are triple the size of anyone around here.

C To be fair, I do think we've got a problem with the climate. I think we need to make some sacrifices.

B I don't mind sacrifice, but who's sacrificing? This young person - and I know you're just doing your job, you're saying what you've been told to say - but you're telling us we need to make sacrifices. What are you giving up?

- It's 2038, it's fifteen years in the future, and it's illegal to have cats as pets. Because antibiotics don't work any more, so if a cat scratches a baby, and it gets infected, that infection will kill them. So the scene is just a cat onstage. Just a secret, illegal cat, just hanging out.

Climate therapy

- It's 2019, it's a therapist's office.

A is a therapist, B is a patient.

B ...I think it's the fact that it's not hypothetical any more. A few years ago it was like, 'maybe this climate thing could happen', but now it's more, racing down the tracks towards us. If I was anxious about something at work, there are steps I could take, you can do something to try and resolve it. But this, there's no resolution.

A Can you talk a bit about what you feel like you're losing?

B I don't know. I'm losing, I guess, my sense of a future. When I was a kid I thought that my life would get easier as it went along, and now I've lost that feeling. I'm losing all these animals and natural spots in the world. I don't know, all these animals and fish, it's not like I see them every day in my life, but it feels like I'm losing something when I hear they're dying... You must be seeing a lot of this stuff at the moment. Eco-anxiety, right?

A I don't call it that, because 'anxiety' implies it's a worry that's exaggerated. But there's nothing exaggerated about what you're describing - so I call it climate distress.

B I'm trying not to talk about it too much because it just kills the conversation dead, but it just goes round and round in my head.

A So what we see a lot is that people tend to process what's happening with the planet in stages. First stage, you might deny or disavow those feelings.

B I'm not denying them.

A No, I think you've moved past that stage, which is great.

B So what's next?

A Well once you've accepted the reality of the problem, you can start adapting to it, get involved in addressing the problem. So the next stage is looking for solutions.

B So like, join a community garden?

A So many options. Because the problem is everywhere, that means the solutions are everywhere, too, right? So it almost doesn't matter where you start, you just want to find something that feels positive, that feels constructive, that feels meaningful. And then just begin.

New reef

\- It's 2023, it's a conference room.

A Welcome everyone, find a seat. Some of you know each other, I think you all know me.

Everyone's signed their NDA, but again just to be crystal clear: you do not discuss what we talk about here. This is not a government project, this is not a university, so the rules are a little different to what some of you may be used to. If that's an issue for anyone, this is your moment to theatrically head to the door. Grab one of those little quiches from the buffet on your way out.

Suzanne, are you literally walking out? Okay, you're fucking with me. Everyone, this is Suzanne, she's a kelp biologist. Thanks Sue.

Alright, let's do the serious stuff. We have here a selection of ocean ecologists, systems engineers, marine sociologists, molecular biologists… Your mission, should you choose to accept it, is to create a brand new ecosystem.

Coral reefs are gone. I don't need to repeat the story, first major biome to completely collapse, 95% destroyed since the year 2000, etc etc. There are still governments trying to save the last remnants of dying reefs, which is understandable but a waste of time. They're gone and they're not coming back.

Unfortunately, we need reefs, or something similar. What has replaced the reefs is algae blooms and slime. We have eight billion mouths to feed and we can't eat algae. I mean Fred probably can, but the rest of us need something else.

So we need an ecosystem that replicates the basic functions of a coral reef. It doesn't have look pretty, it just needs to keep the slime at bay and provide food for billions of people. Simple as that.

Let's break it down. First we need something to replace the corals themselves. These are like the trees in the forest, they harvest sunlight and they create the the habitat for other organisms to live. What can we replace them with? This is where you come in. Siliceous sponges, oysters... any good filter feeders that create three-dimensional structures for other organisms to work around.

Secondly we need something to vacuum up planktonic microalgae. We've got a lot of fertiliser run-off in the ocean, algae grows fast in warm acidic water. We need something that eats algae fast or we're going to have non-stop algae blooms. We're looking at copepods and little planktivorous fish - again, this is open for you to throw in.

Thirdly, we need something to harvest the benthic microalgae growing on the seafloor. We could go for sea urchins - they're tough, they're survivors - but they have a tendency to boom and bust, and we're looking for something a little more stable. Maybe some little schooling fish, siganids, rabbitfish… Felicity, I know your group has some thoughts on this.

Last piece of the puzzle is us. We need to work out a way to harvest this production for human beings. We might need a species or two to do some consolidation work, like whales have done for us in the past - but eventually we need to be able to harvest these fish, we want to eat this reef.

What we have to work with are the ecosystems we have left on the planet: crops, livestock, weeds and pests. These are the building blocks of the new world.

Once again, you are not doing press, you are not giving comments, you are not backgrounding anyone. We are not talking, we're doing. This is the Manhattan Project of ecosystem design.

So. There's coffee in the foyer, I'll show you the lab, and then let's get to work.

Budj Bim

- It's six thousand years ago, at Budj Bim in Victoria. The Gunditjmara people build a huge system of eel traps. An adapted landscape for eel farming.
- You can picture it here laid out on the floor. It's a series of traps that channels eels from the river into a set of pools of water for harvesting.
- The farm is designed to only trap mature eels - it lets younger fish escape so that the population can be maintained.
- Just imagine the engineering skill it requires requires to move hundred of tons of basalt rock to create these weirs and dams and channels - the ecological knowledge it takes to create a completely sustainable freshwater aquaculture system…
- And this system operates for thousands of years. People here sat around campfires and ate eels, cooked with daisy yams, grass seeds...
- Goanna roasted with local sweet potato...
- And then European settlement. And then it lies dormant for more than 200 years. The traps are overrun by vegetation, the river shrinks to a trickle.
- Now it's December 2019. Huge bushfires rip through the area. They strip away all this vegetation that's grown over the traps.
- Now it's February 2020, and the rains come down, and water starts flowing through the traps. And the whole system just starts working again.
- This machine is older than the Pyramids, older than Stonehenge, and it still works.

A nightclub

- It's 2031, it's two hours south of Beijing, a nightclub.

MUSIC: Maurice Louca - Al-Mashoub

A and B are dancing.

A I need some air!

B What?

A I need some fresh air!

They step outside.

A That's better. Ahhh, that's nice.

B Do you want some k?

A Sorry, what?

B Bump of ketamine?

A I'm good, thanks.

B Okay. (snorts) So how come you're going so hard in there?

A What do you mean?

B Like you're headbanging. You're trying to shake something off, or what?

A I flew a mission today.

B What do you mean? 'Flew' as in…?

A I flew - above the earth - in a plane.

B You're a pilot?

A nods.

B So what kind of mission?

A You heard of stratospheric aerosol injection?

B You're the ones blacking out the sun.

A No, I'm saving the planet.

B Okay, sure. How does that work?

A So this morning, I took off from Tienyang Base in a KC-135 Stratotanker with a cargo of about 30 tons of sulfur dioxide. With me?

B Sure.

A I take off and I rise up through the clouds until the curve of the earth becomes clear, and the sky goes from blue to black. Then I get to the stratosphere, around 40, 50 kilometres above the earth. And then I deploy the payload. I shed all this sulfur dioxide and it streams out like a silvery cloud behind me.

B Sulfur dioxide is…

A Acid. Sulfuric acid. And all these little droplets of acid reflect back sunlight and they form a bright cloud up in the sky and they stop the sun from shining so brightly on the earth. Which means that in the eighteen months since we started doing this, we've cooled the planet down by a full degree, which is why we're not soaked in sweat right now.

B I'm still soaked with sweat.

A Yeah but you've had ketamine.

B That's fair. And this is your job?

A Nine missions a week for the next eight months. And then in two or three years time, when all the sulfur's fallen out of the sky, we'll do it again.

B So what, you're decompressing right now?

A I'm having a night off from saving the world.

B Alright. You want to go back in and dance?

A Yes I fucking do.

A and B head back in to the beats, which get louder and louder -

---

- and now we're in the full flow of this Maurice Louca tune, in a nightclub, just, in love with dancing.

Nub par: waves on sand

It's a dinner party! A is washing up, B and C are helping. D and E are sitting by the stereo.

E I'm saying, there are no climate anthems.

D There are heaps of songs about the climate.

E There are songs about the climate, but they're not anthems, because they suck.

A Sorry, you'll have you use a scourer on that pan. It had the non-stick stuff on it, but I used the wrong scrubber on it and I've fucked it.

D I can straight away think of a massive climate anthem.

E There are lots of artists who've tried, but it's impossible. You can't write a song about something so big and abstract. They try too hard and it's too earnest and it sucks.

D That's what I'm saying. The best climate anthems were never actually meant to be about the climate crisis.

Okay so there's basically one iconic climate anthem. You hear it at every climate march, all around the world. The chorus gets quoted in news headlines, on TV. It wasn't intended to be political, but it just said the right thing at the right moment.

B I can't guess it.

D You'll know it. Can I connect my phone to the bluetooth?

A Go for it.

C I don't think it's a crisis.

B Sorry, what?

C You said 'climate crisis' - I'm just saying, I don't think it's a crisis.

E Oh come on, fuck off.

A No, give him a chance. He's got his degree in climate... something-ology, this is his actual job.

C I think calling it a crisis is a bad way of looking at it.

E Climate change is real, it's a crisis. Like there are farmers now who have to plant rice at night, wearing headlamps, because it's too hot to be out in the daytime. You don't think that's happening?

C I don't mean it's not happening. I mean, look, when did humans begin changing the climate? Decades ago, centuries, before any of us were born. And these changes won't stop until long after we're dead.

If climate is a crisis, then all of us alive today were born in the crisis. And we'll die in the crisis, we live our whole lives inside the crisis. I'm saying it's too big to be a crisis.

B You've started him off now, he's in full flow.

C Sorry, I'm not trying to make a big thing of it.

B No, it's beautiful, keep going.

C That's it, that's all I'm saying. It's too big to be a crisis.

A So what is it then, if it's not a crisis?

C I think it's an era. I think it's a period in history, like the medieval era or the renaissance. We're living today in the early years of the climate era.

B See I find that really stressful. It's just going to get worse and worse, our whole lives.

E Yeah, it's gonna keep unravelling, hey. Like, the 20s will be more extreme than the 10s. The 30s will be even more chaotic. The 40s will be worse, the 50s worse again, the 60s... We're never going to see a new normal.

A So when does it end?

C What do you mean?

A Eras end, right? The medieval era ended, the renaissance ended. Does the climate era end?

E It ends when we all burn to death or drown in a flood or whatever.

C No, you see, your problem is, you keep talking about these climate shocks like they're the end of the world. But they're not. There's no end of the world, there's no apocalypse.

A You were the one saying how bad things are going to get.

C Yeah, absolutely. But if we're talking about the climate era, as a historical period, the shocks aren't the end, they're the beginning. We pushed the planet past its breaking point, and now it's starting to blow back in our face. But that's just the opening act. Once those shocks hit, that just means the climate era has begun. We're really in it. And we'll be in it for generations to come.

B Fuck, man.

E See this is why we invite you to things. She brings the shoplifted supermarket flowers, you bring the existential dread.

D Sorry, I think someone's connected to the bluetooth.

A Shit, that might be me, sorry. Hang on.

D My phone does this. It will just connect at some point and the song will just start out of nowhere.

B So if the climate era goes for generations - when does it end?

E I mean, does it matter? If none of us are going to see it. No-one alive is going to see it - does it matter when it ends?

B Yeah it matters. I want to know that we're going to get through this. Even if none of us gets to see it, I want to know that there's an end to this.

E It's not gonna be like the end of World War 2, though. There won't be people out in the street hugging, saying 'yay, climate change is over'. By the time it's really over, people probably won't even think about it any more, they won't care.

B That's what I want, though. When will people no longer have to care about this thing?

C I mean it's fuzzy, right? A historical period doesn't have an official end date. But I think you'll know it's over when you hear the sound of waves on sand again.

E Is someone going to bite? Okay, fine: what do you mean, waves on sand?

C You know the sound. The wave crashes, sand flung up on the strand, water draws back, the crash again.

A And that's the end of the climate era.

C Yes, because it means the beaches have come back. Look, we've already locked in enough warming to raise the oceans by a metre or so. Even if we stopped emitting tomorrow, that's already enough to wash away every beach in the world. Within the century, all those strips of sand go underwater.

E So what, then - the shoreline is just rock and mud and grass?

C That's it, yep. And where we are now, maybe it'll be underwater, maybe not. But nowhere in the world will there be that sound of waves on sand.

But then once the seas settle, then wherever the shore is shallow enough, the tide starts washing up grains of sand, a few at a time.

So I don’t know when, but maybe a thousand years from now, there’ll be new beaches on new coastlines on a whole new map of the world. People lying on towels, making sandcastles, bodysurfing, skinny-dipping. Imagine someone walking down to the water for a swim at the end of the day, on a beach that doesn’t exist yet. That’s when you know we’ve made it through.

Banks and net zero

- It's 2019, a bank office in London.

A is a bank executive, B is their junior.

B You wanted to see me?

A Yeah, I thought I'd let you know - I just got off the phone to the CRO and the CFO - looks like we're not going to be financing the gas field.

B That's fucking great.

A Yeah, it's good news. Seems like the protests got to them. That public letter from the shareholder activists got good traction, plus I think the CFO doesn't like having his car mobbed by Extinction Rebellion when he pulls into the carpark.

B Fucking 'disco dance for the climate' kids following you to work, I can't think of anything worse.

A Well exactly.

Instant snap to another part of the stage, another time, another place, another world.

- I wake up at 6am and check the forecast.

And then instantly we're back.

A So they're going to announce at the shareholder meeting - we're pulling out of the gas field project, and we're reassessing our loans to the cement factory and the port expansion.

B Great.

A Yeah, I thought you'd be pleased. One other thing. I chatted with IT about the leak.

B …right.

A It wasn't a hack. That was the first thing they said.

B So what did, I mean how did…?

A Their guess is that someone copied minutes from the board meeting on to a thumb drive and handed it to Greenpeace. Someone in this office.

B Okay. So what are IT going to…?

A I told them not to worry about it. I mean, we're cancelling the gas field financing anyway, what's the difference.

B Right.

A But if you ever fucking do that to me again… We don't air our dirty laundry in public. That's not how we work.

B But you said it was the protests that tipped them over on this.

A This time. This one time. But if you ever go behind my back like that again, I will fucking end you. We are trying to turn the wheel of a very big ship, and the last thing I need is surprise fucking allies. Alright?

X-shredder mouse

- It's 2022, Gough Island, near Antarctica in the South Atlantic Ocean.

A is a journalist, B is a scientist.

A So this is the mouse?

B This is the mouse.

A It looks like an ordinary mouse.

B We call it an X-shredder mouse.

A And he's going to kill every single other mouse on this island?

B That's right.

A Can I ask... how?

B Well, mice came here with human ships in the 20th century and they have devastated native animals on this island. They eat bird eggs -

A No, I understand how invasive species work. I mean how does this mouse eradicate every other mouse on the island?

B Well, we've used a tool called Crispr to change part of this mouse's genome. you've heard of Crispr?

A Yeah, it lets you rewrite bits of DNA.

B That's right. Now mice are like us, they have two sex-determining chromosomes. XX is female, XY is male. With the X-shredder mouse, we've edited his genome so all his X-bearing sperm are defective. That knocks half the sperm out of his gene pool. He cannot have female children.

A So all his mouse babies will be boys?

B That's right. And those male children can only have male children, and their children, and so on. With each generation, the sex imbalance grows, and within a few generations, there are no females left to reproduce. And so the mouse population on this island suddenly goes down to zero.

A That is… that seems extreme.

B No, what's extreme is that for the last half century, since the sixties, we've been dealing with invasive rodents on all these islands around the world by dropping anticoagulant poison on them. Now that's a grim way to go. Internal bleeding, slow, painful. And of course all these other animals eat the poison

too, or they eat the poisoned mice, and so it spreads. But that's humans, isn't it? First we ship a species around the world, then we poison it by helicopter.

A But using genetic engineering to destroy an entire population - doesn't that feel a bit… genocidal?

B I guess. But also, this island is the home of the last two thousand breeding pairs of Tristan albatross. And the mice are killing them. You can go up on that hill there in springtime and see gangs of mice attacking albatross chicks and eating them alive. So this is genocide to stop genocide.

A Okay, but what if one of these X-shredder mice gets off the island and into the rest of the world? Like if this spread, it would kill every mouse in the world, right? What if this solution ends up causing a whole other problem?

B You're absolutely right. This could be a disaster. We could end up regretting this for the rest of our lives. But we should be clear about what we're choosing between. Our choice is not between 'the world as it used to be' and this risky solution. The choice is between this risky solution and nothing. A wasteland. The extermination of all these other species. Which we caused. So if we choose not to intervene and let it happen - it's still our fault. So look, I don't know if this is a good idea. I worry about this night and day. So what would you do?

Rice fields

A rice field, the middle of the night. A group of farmers wearing headlamps move slowly through the flooded field, wearing headlamps, planting rice in silence.

Pipeline attacks

- It's 2022, it's a courtroom.

A We've heard your testimony that you were 'distressed' about the climate.

B I am distressed.

A Do you think that distress gives you the right to break into a construction site and ignite an explosive on the front seat of a truck?

B No.

A So you don't believe you have the right?

B It's shareholder value. These companies aren't going to listen to reason, they don't care about the science. The only way they're going to stop investing in these new mines is if the cost outweighs the benefit. So now hopefully they know it's a financial risk.

A So you think that by setting off a petrol bomb on a construction site you're sending a message to shareholders?

B Don't get me wrong, ten years ago I would have said this was unacceptable. But now it's ten years later.

Snap to elsewhere.

- I wake up at 6am, check the forecast. Expected maximum, 55 degrees celcius.

And back.

A So why not join a peaceful protest?

B There's nothing wrong with non-violent protest. But look: in the US Civil Rights movement, you had Martin Luther King pushing for non-violent action. But Martin Luther King needed Malcolm X, he needed the Black Panthers. He needed to be able to say, 'I'm the reasonable one. Come talk to me, or else you're going to have to deal with them.' The only way Extinction Rebellion get any traction is if there's another group out there, willing to do actual damage.

A You mean letting down the tyres of cars?

B Oh you like that, fucking up SUVs? Mate if that's your thing, go for it. But no, I'm talking about disabling the infrastructure that is killing us. Look, we can't negotiate with these companies. They don't care about future generations, bushfire smoke, crop failure, they can't. They're designed to focus on accumulating money, short-term returns. So we have to teach them - if they won't compromise, neither will we.

Backtail was heavy

- It's 2024, outside a publishing house in London.

A Hey excuse me, can I get a comment on this global fossil shutdown thing?

B What's this?

A These activists calling for drone attacks on oil pipelines. They're saying it's going to kick off this year in Pakistan, Colombia, Nigeria, everywhere. You saw that statement?

B You want to quote me on this? Okay, I think this eco-terrorist stuff, it's a western fantasy. People in the developing world aren't one climate shock away from attacking fossil fuels. Trust me - everyone in those countries understands that energy is how you escape poverty.

The problem is not fossil fuels. The problem is that one group of countries has used more than their fair share.

During the floods in Pakistan, did you hear anyone there talking about blowing up power plants? No. People talked about reparations, about global justice.

If there's another round of floods or a heatwave in Pakistan, and people attack something, it won't be the oil pipelines. It'll be the consulates of rich countries.

Hope is the enemy

- It's 2023, a research institution.

A So, your first TV interview?

B That's right.

A Congratulations. Well this won't take long, we'll run through some general guidelines, and then we'll get you in front of the camera and talk about mic technique.

B I get one of those things clipped to my lapel?

A A lapel mic, yeah. So, we've got three rules for communicating climate science. These are tips that we've developed over the years. We want you to keep these in your head, cause we want your work to get the response it deserves, we want people to hear this stuff and take action. Alright? Number one - no numbers, no statistics.

B This report is all numbers.

A Well, try to not use them. People hear percentages, ratios, they switch off. Number two - no politics. You're just giving the facts, you're not taking sides.

B You don't think climate's political?

A If people think that you're trying to push your political agenda, they will disengage. Your job is information, not policy.

B I'm not the one who's politicised - no, never mind. Yep, fine.

A And number three - you have to be hopeful.

B How do you mean?

A Don't be doom and gloom. Communicate that this is serious, but you need to inspire people, not scare them.

B How do I not scare people? I'm scared.

A Give people something constructive to do. 'If we take action now, we can avoid these dangerous outcomes.' But you have to leave people with hope.

B Why is it up to the people bringing the bad news to also conjure up some good news? I'm an atmospheric chemist, I'm not a cheerleader.

A Because if people don't have hope, they don't take action.

B Right, the people who won't lift a finger to fight for their own planet unless you promise them a good outcome. These people, if you take that excuse away from them, they'll find another one. You can't sell hope to people like that.

A I want to be very clear: you cannot say 'things are tough, we're screwed.' That's not helpful. Honestly, it's nihilistic.

B I think lying about it, pretending it's all going to work out, that's selfish. It's not 2005 any more. We've lost the Greenland ice sheet, the West Antarctic ice sheet, we've crossed these tipping points, we're in a different world now.

A Hope isn't saying it's all going to work out - hope is about believing that what we do matters. Hope is what gives us a reason to fight for a better future.

B You don't need hope for that. You don't hope that you find something to eat tomorrow, you get up and do something about it.

A Why would anyone get up in the morning if they think the future is fucked?

B I don't know, because they do. We do. You feel despair, and it washes over you, and then you get up and keep fighting. It doesn't mean you don't care, it doesn't mean you can't feel joy, it just means you've let go of hope.

A You want to just give in to despair?

B Why not? I think you're scared to feel despair, because you think if you despair, you'll never be happy again.

A Okay, stop for a second. You're obviously struggling, I can see that. Let me explain - when we're processing this huge planetary transformation, we go through three stages. First stage is denial -

B I know.

A And then you search for solutions -

B I know about the stages, I'm not interested. Listen, I don't need people spraying hope at me. The reason we're in this mess is that we kept hoping things would get better. Hope is what chains us to this system, hope is the enemy.

A You're on live TV, the camera's rolling, and you're going to tell people they should despair?

B I'm going to say, it's time to look the facts in the face. The world we knew is already gone, and there is no-one coming to save us.

Evac Bingo

A I wake up at 6am, check the forecast.

\- It's 2042, Western Sydney.

A Expected maximum, 55 degrees celcius. Tenth straight day of more than 50 degrees.

There's only one room in the apartment with an aircon unit, so all four of us sleep in there with the curtains drawn.

Gabe's been going out each evening after dark to buy food. The rest of us haven't left the apartment in over a week.

Alice isn't sleeping. She wakes and cries, then fusses, drifts off for a minute, wakes again. Cal goes back and forth - one minute he's bored and restless, wants to go and play with his friends, next he's lying on the floor staring at the wall saying nothing.

I remember covid when I was a little girl, we weren't allowed to leave the house. This is like that, except we can't even leave the room. When I get up to go to the bathroom, it's so hot in the corridor I feel like I can't breathe.

At 2pm, the aircon unit suddenly turns off.

AUDIO: The aircon sound cuts out.

A At first we think it's loose wiring. Then we check our phones. It's a brownout. Eight thousand houses in Western Sydney have lost power.

\- It's 2032, central coast of New South Wales.

B Yesterday they upgraded the storm to category 3 and they said it was heading for Newcastle. Today they upgraded it to category 4, and said it's shifted south, going to make landfall in Woy Woy tonight. The government alert says, 'go to the evacuation shelter'. But mum won't go. She went to the shelter in the last flood, she says she won't go back.

A The air in the apartment is already getting stuffy and thick. There's a government alert saying all households without aircon should get to a public cooling centre as quickly as possible.

Gabe fills all the plastic bottles he can carry with water from the sink. We put Alice in the pram with ice cubes wrapped in teatowels next to her. We dress Cal in long sleeves and a hat. They're both crying, they don't understand. Before we leave, we pour water all over ourselves til we're drenched - then we step out into the street.

A pours water all over themselves (again).

B Mum says, the shelter's dirty, it's crowded, it's noisy. There's only camp beds, there's no privacy. There's no food. If you go to sleep, people steal your money, they steal your phone, right out of your bag. I'm not doing it.

I say, mum, what is your actual problem? If something happened to you there, tell me what it was. I will make sure it doesn't happen again. But we have to go. I can't push your wheelchair up the hill through the rain. If the water gets any higher, we're stuck. We need to be somewhere safe.

She says, trust me, the shelter's not safe. Not for women.

- It's 2021, COP26 in Glasgow.

C There's thousands of us marching. The diplomats are inside the Blue Zone, negotiating or getting selfies with Obama or Bezos, and we're out on the street protesting three decades of failure.

Everyone's cheering, everyone's chanting, we're singing that one climate anthem that always gets sung, and it feels like there's an energy, it feels like if we keep pushing, something's going to give way.

And the protest finishes, I'm on the train home, and I'm tired and I'm hungry, and I've still got all this adrenaline and exhilaration, and all of a sudden it all just surges up in me, and I have this strange sensation.

- It's 2025, New South Wales.

D I've been reading everything I can about what's coming. And what I'm reading is, the cities are not going to be safe. When the shocks hit, the supply chain crises, there's going to be no food, no water, you're going to be starving in the street.

If you want to get through this, you need your own food, your own water. You need land. You want somewhere cool, temperate, reliable rainfall. In Australia, you want to be in the Huon Valley, the Grampians or the Blue Mountains.

I finally pull the trigger and buy a quarter acre out near Lithgow. I set up a water tank, solar array, my own septic tank system, water filter, a big garden for veggies. And when I finally get up here I think, I'm 100% self-sufficient. And I breathe a sigh of relief.

One week later, someone drops a cigarette on the side of the road outside Lithgow. Within a day there's 20 fire warnings on the RFS website and the roads are closing all the way down to Katoomba.

B 4.40pm. The clouds are getting heavy and it's already getting dark. We can see the waves on the bay getting whipped by the wind. Finally my mum says, okay, we'll go to the shelter. And I call the number for the emergency buses.

Forty minutes later, the bus pulls up. But as soon as it arrives, we can see, there's no way to get a wheelchair on board. I say to the driver, they promised the vehicles would be wheelchair accessible, I checked. He says, I just came where they told me. I'm sorry, but there's no way I can get that on board. I've got to keep going.

And he pulls out and keeps driving. And already on the horizon we can hear the thunder.

C I suddenly get this feeling of, what are we doing this for? Are we trying to hold back the tide? Are we standing in the surf trying to push the waves back to sea with our bare hands?

And I think to myself, you know what - if ice wants to melt, it should melt. If carbon dioxide wants to increase, it should increase. If the ice caps decide that it's time to pour their glaciers into the sea, then they don't have to listen to us pleading with them to stop, they should just go ahead.

A It's like stepping into a furnace.

On the other side of the street I can see someone slumped in the shade under an awning. They're wrapped up in clothes, can't tell if it's a man or a woman, they're not moving.

There are other families out, all shuffling down Mulgoa and Castlereagh. No-one speaks. Sirens in the distance, generators sputtering, no other sound.

The whole sky is burned white, it's like walking in the slow motion flash of a nuclear bomb.

D I got my gloves, protective gear, hoses, the water tank - but I can't defend this whole property all by myself. And the sky's turning dark with smoke and there's that roaring wind that sounds like thunder, like continuous thunder.

And I think maybe I should get out of here before it's too late. I think surely there's a way out, some sort of route on the back roads, but I don't know this area. My family's down on the coast. I don't know the neighbours, I don't know who's here, who's evacuated, I don't have anyone to call. I'm completely on my own.

I think, it's not land you need to survive, it's community, it's people. No-one gets through this on their own. And I realise I've made a very big mistake.

C And this plastic water bottle I'm holding, it doesn't want to be some carefully moulded consumer item that fits in my hand, it wants to be a million microscopic plastic particles scattered in the sea, getting eaten by krill and fish and ending up getting stuck in my intestines.

Every bit of plastic wants to become dust, that's all. And it will! And it should! All the plastic in the world is going to become a fine jagged dust that never goes away. And we shouldn't try to hold it back!

If animals want to go extinct, then we should let them go. If the world wants mosquitoes instead of jaguars, then the world should get what the world wants!

B 5pm. We need to get somewhere secure before the wind hits. I pile our bags on mum's lap and push the wheelchair down to the church on Point Street by the waterfront. The wind is already picking up, the rain is starting to pound down.

Out in the bay, the wind is blowing all the water out towards the ocean, it's like a low low tide, you can see strips of seaweed in the sand. It's eerie, I've never seen anything like it.

By the time we get to the church, the wind is shrieking, the rain is pounding like hammers. 7pm, a tree branch smashes into the window, and then there's rain pouring in on the floor. Mum says, we got to get down into the basement. And I help her down the stairs, very slowly.

Around 11pm, it all gets really quiet. The wind stops, the rain stops, it's all very still. For a minute I think it's finished, we're safe. But mum says, no, that's the eye of the storm passing overhead. And then from down towards the bay, there's a sound.

C I got a million tiny fragments of plastic running in my bloodstreams, I got more plastic in me than any human in any generation that came before me, I'm an animal like this world has never seen before, every lungful of air takes in 420 parts per million carbon dioxide, it's in me, this thing is in me, and I shouldn't be happy about it, I shouldn't be happy, I should feel sad and sorry and guilty, but it's rushing through me like a wave, and I can't stop smiling -

D It starts to get dark, there's smoke and ash in the air, the sky turns red, then purple, then black.

I can see it moving over the treetops towards me, faster than I expected - I get a glimpse of fire, and less than twenty seconds later, it's on me.

A Cal is heavy in my arms. Gabe is pushing the pram and carrying the bottles of water, he's sagging. We try to hurry but I feel like I'm going to throw up if I go too fast. I want to check that Alice is okay but I'm scared to lift up the flap on the pram and expose her to the sun.

We turn the corner to the old Penrith shopping mall. Dozens of other families ahead of us, coming down High Street. Cross the street, down the ramp into the old underground carpark, out of the sun, and we take a deep breath.

Gabe gets the water out of his bag, opens the pram, checks on Alice. I go to give Cal a drink, but he's not moving.

B It's this rushing sound, like someone's left the sink running. And I don't know what it is, but it's getting louder.

And then I have this snap realisation. I get the whole picture in my head in one go. When we came to the church, the wind was pushing the water in the bay out to sea. We could see the bare sand.

But now the eye of the storm's passed overhead, the wind is now blowing the other direction, it's pushing all that water back to shore.

That's the sound of water surging up the bay, over the headland, on to Point Street, right over the church.

D There's embers coming down in the garden like baseballs hitting the ground. I see one the size of my head crash into the bush by the veranda and explode in flames.

There's trees igniting in one burst, just exploding. Birds burning on the branches. Fences on fire, tree stumps, tanbark, cars. The plastic in my sunglasses is starting to melt.

A Gabe gets up and runs - I don't know how, but he runs - for the Red Cross nurse at the entrance. But there are other families in front of us, we're at the back of the crowd. And I think no, this is not happening, I am not letting this happen. And Cal's breathing in little gasps, and I'm kneeling on the tarmac, splashing him with water,

B And the water's in the church over our head now, and it's pouring down the basement steps and it's up to my waist and rising

D And the flames are rising on all sides, two storeys high, smacking into the side of the house over and over like waves

C And there's waves of feeling rushing through me and I'm shaking with it, everything in me is alive

A And I'm breathing fast and the panic's rising in me

B And I'm squeezing mum's hand and the water's rushing down on us

D And I'm holding my breath and the fire's flowing in from all sides

C And it's glowing in my chest and I'm laughing out loud

A And then it all comes apart in me

B And it all goes very dark

D And it's so bright I can't see

C And I can see everything, and it all fits.

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everything everything everything everything

Snapshots

E But the shocks aren't the end, they're the beginning. The shocks are just the opening act, and then we're really in the climate era.

- It's a street in Santiago, there's protestors using handheld lasers to knock out police drones.

- It's Austin, protestors are using wooden catapults to fling petrol bombs at police lines.

- It's Cairo, they're burning banks and office buildings.

- It's Sydney, they're smashing boutique windows with iron bars.

- It's a banana plantation in Mexico and a fungal infection has wiped out the crop and they're burning piles of banana leaves.

- It's the west of Iceland and there's a huge facility drawing carbon out of the air and injecting it into basalt rock.

- It's a half-flooded house by the port of Melbourne and two teenagers are getting drunk on an old mattress upstairs.

- It's the Himalayas and a melting glacier has burst a dam and there's a village trying to evacuate up the slope before the water hits.

- It's the northeast of Scotland and a farmer has just shot two wolves from a pack released into the highlands.

- It's a board room in Amsterdam and oil and gas prices are collapsing and there's a fossil fuel executive demanding taxpayer bail-outs.

- It's a mink fur farm in Russia and one of the workers has just started coughing from a new virus that no human has ever caught before.

- It's South Australia and a family of white rhinos are being released into the Australian bush outside Broken Hill.

- It's Perth and someone's turning on the taps but there's no water coming out.

- It's Venezuela and there's an explosion outside a lithium mine.

- It's eight years from now and you're sitting in a hospital waiting room and the doctor said they'd give you an update an hour ago but no-one's telling you anything and you still don't know -

- It's 15 years from now and the streets are blocked and you're panicking trying to figure out how to get home -

- It's 21 years from now and there's smoke in the air and you're struggling to breathe -

- It's 35 years from now and you're laughing so hard you can't breathe and there's a joy bubbling up in you -

- It's the future and there's so much panic and so much joy still to come -

- It's generations from now and everything you're worried about has happened or it never will, and someone who hasn't even been born yet is waking up to make breakfast for their kids -

- It's the future and the tide keeps rising and the beaches are washed away and the water keeps coming in -

E Cause maybe there's no end to this process. You go through all the stages - denial, solutions, grief - and then you find hope. And then you lose it again. And you go back to denial, back to the start, you begin the whole cycle again.

AUDIO: Underneath, the sound of waves on sand gently starts to build.

- It's the future and the government's not holding together and there's a man teaching his son how to shave -

E Maybe you'll spend the rest of your life processing this thing, and you'll never come to a final conclusion.

- It's the future and there's gunfire getting closer and there's a couple kissing by the water -

- It's the future and there's someone standing just where you are now, worried about the same things -

- It's early morning and there's smoke over the forest -

- It's a hot afternoon and there's the smell of cooking on the street corner -

- It's early evening and the stars are coming out -

- It's twilight, and someone is stretching at the end of a long day, and they're walking down to the water for a swim.

Post-everything

A

I step outside just as the sun is going down. It's a hot night, the air is shimmering, the insects are thronging.

I walk down the hill towards the harbour. Someone's playing music out of an upstairs window, I can smell someone cooking goanna and sweet potatoes.

There's an old drunk sitting on the steps outside an apartment building, and he points when he sees me.

He says, 'You know this city, this you know what this city used to be called? They used to call it Sydney.'

I say, 'Thanks, but I got enough history at school.
I'm meeting some friends for a swim. Have a good night.'

And I walk down towards the water, and the breeze is coming off the sea.

The sound of waves on sand.

The sound of a phone connecting to a bluetooth speaker.

MUSIC: Nelly - Hot in Herre

End.

BONUS SCENES!

This is a selection of other scenes which you are welcome to add in.

Living through extinction

\- It's 2064, it's a restaurant.

A is a young person, B is an older person.

A But what was it like living through it all?

B Living through all of what?

A All the extinctions. Like you were alive when the Western Black Rhino went extinct, what was that like?

B When was that?

A 2011.

B I didn't really notice.

A The last rhino died, and you were alive when it happened, and you didn't notice?

B Look, it was a busy year. Maybe I read about it, I don't remember? It wasn't a big thing at the time. I remember, I think that was when the Occupy protests were happening? These big protests against inequality. And the Arab Spring, which was a whole set of revolutions... That Gotye song came out. (hums the riff to Somebody That I Used To Know.)

A That mass extinction was the biggest thing you ever lived through. Those species existed since before we were human, and now they're gone forever - and you were there when it happened.

B Look, you have to trust me - when you live through a big historic moment for the planet, it doesn't feel like it's that important. We knew there was a mass extinction happening, we all felt bad about it. But you didn't think about it every second of every day. 2011, I had a bad breakup that year, I was in a shit job, I was trying to pay rent. We weren't thinking about the big picture all the time, we were trying to live our lives.

Getting home safely

- It's 2014, a stadium concert in Manila.

A and B are dancing and cheering.

A Hey, have you checked your phone?

B What?

A There's a flood alert for everything south of EDSA. They say, if you need to use those roads, do it now.

B He hasn't finished yet.

A Come on, he's done, we've got to get moving. The water's going to be up over the road in another hour.

B He's going to do an encore. He hasn't done any of his raps yet. He has to come out and do that.

A I'm not risking my life to see Ed Sheeran do raps. It's not worth it.

B You're wrong.

A Look at this alert! The river is literally coming up, it's happening. We're going to drown in a taxi!

B You're wrong. He's a very good rapper. People just jump to conclusions because of what he looks like, but if they listened to his flow...

A Okay. Yes he is. Yes, you're right, those rhymes are tight. Okay. One rap and then we make a break for it.

Audience cheers, A and B join in cheering, and then over the top of it we hear the sound of Ed Sheeran's 'Don't'. A beatboxes, B raps a verse.

B I met this girl late last year

She said 'don't you worry if I disappear'

I said 'I'm not really looking for another mistake'

I called an old friend, thinking that the trouble could wait

But then I jumped right in a week later it turned

I reckon she was only looking for a lover to burn...

Interludes

These are small interludes that can be scattered throughout the show if you like.

- It's 2028, it's five years from now, and the scene is a press conference. It's the Australian prime minister, they're very serious, very stern, looking down the barrel of the camera, they're saying, '…as of next year, Australia will be shifting to the European academic calendar - the school year will start in August and run til June. Due to increased bushfire risk, it's no longer safe to be taking family holidays to the beach during summer.'
- It's 2034, it's an abbatoir, and the manager is in the office on the phone to McDonalds, and he's on the verge of tears, like, 'you can't be serious'. And the McDonalds exec is like, 'look it's not you, it's just, at this stage, plant-based meat is just cheaper and more reliable, we're making the switch for all our burgers. I want you to know that... we don't regret a thing. But it's over.'
- It's 2026, and the scene is a gym with all the treadmills taped off. On one side of the stage you've got a gym receptionist who's like, sorry, the aircon can't cope with the smoke from the bushfires, so we're temporarily banning cardio. And then on the other side, facing off with them, you've got a crossfit instructor with his flock behind him, and he's saying, you think fire is gonna stop us from getting our gains? Fam if you don't let us use those machines, imma drop to the ground right here and do push-ups until I have a stroke. And that's on you.

This one can be called, It Was Late And I Was Tired

The end of earth science

Two people fill up sand into a bag. When they finish, one says:

- It's 2017. You're in a conference hall with twenty thousand earth scientists. There are talks on -
- Wind Stress Forcing in the Western Boundary Current of the North Pacific Subtropical Gyre.
- Analysing Dissolved Carbon Concentration in Subtropical Rivers in Northern Taiwan.
- Radial propagation of substorm injections.
- Using soil probes to detect open-path eddy covariance.
- What is Earth System science?
- It's the study of the planet we live on.
- The atmosphere, the hydrosphere, cryosphere, geosphere, lithosphere, biosphere, magnetosphere -
- It's biology, it's geology, it's chemistry, meteorology, oceanography, climatology, economics, sociology -
- It's the scientific effort to create a unifying vision of the earth.
- So who's behind this effort?
- You got the United Nations Environment Programme, the UNEP, formed in 1972 when the UN holds its first big conference on the environment.
- In 1979 the UNEP sets up the World Climate Research Programme, the WCRP, to determine whether the climate is really changing and if humans are responsible.
- By 1986 it's clear that climate change is just one part of the bigger phenomenon of global change, so the WCRP creates a new organisation to look at the bigger picture called the International Geosphere-Biosphere Programme, the IGBP.
- The WCRP and the IGBP are uncovering shocking things about what's happening to the planet, so in 1988 scientists set up a new body to assess this science and present it to government: the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, or the IPCC.
- So the UNEP, the WCRP, the IGBP and the IPCC bring together researchers at events like the American and the European Geophysicists Union General Assemblies, the AGU and the EGU.

- So now if someone asks you, ‘When did scientists start formally collaborating to model the earth system?’ you can say, 1972. And if they ask, ‘Who are the organisations behind that effort?’ you can say, I don’t know, some acronyms.
- These organisations sound boring from the outside. But look closer. Once you get inside them, they’re more boring than you could even begin to imagine.
- These organisations brought together tens of thousands of researchers. Each researcher grappling with one tiny piece of the puzzle. Spending their whole life trying to understand one tiny fragment of how the planet works.
- When you combine these puzzle pieces, for the first time, we begin to get a picture of the world we live in.
- A single complex system comprised of countless sub-systems.
- So complex that no single person can understand the whole thing. It takes tens of thousands of experts with overlapping expertise.
- And when they put it all together, what did they see?
- Well.
- Most of the time, throughout history, knowledge equals power. But every once in a while, very rarely, knowledge threatens power.
- Earth scientists are not wild revolutionaries.
- They’re boring, curious, obsessive weirdos.
- What kind of person would devote their entire life to studying wind flow over low-lying plant canopies?
- But without meaning to, these scientists discovered something that was not good news for the powers that be.
- By accident, these scientists discovered something that destabilised the entire global political order.
- And they were not ready for the blowback.

Shooting a wolf

Sandbags added to the wall.

\- 2031, outside a magistrate's court, Inverness.

A is a journalist, B is a farmer.

A Have you been sentenced?

B I've got a statement - can I read my statement please?

A Have you been sentenced to prison or just a fine?

B Do you want to hear what I have to say? Okay, thank you. I want to say, we've had a gutful of people from the city coming up and telling us how to live. This has been going on for centuries, folk from universities writing these great theses about how we should farm, what we can and can't grow. And now they're coming up here and putting predators on our land. This law is wrong, these creatures are wrong - they don't belong here. I don't care if they used to live here a thousand years ago. We live here now, and we're trying to farm, and that's our job, that's our livelihood.

A But they weren't on your land when you shot them. They were geotagged, they were still on the nature reserve. They never came on your land.

B Look mate, if you want wolves, why don't you have them? You want to rewild somewhere, rewild the city. Put them in your local park, see how you like sending your kids to school with a pack of predators in the streets. But this whole rewilding thing is a joke, it's not scientific. You want to save the environment, clean up your own mess. Don't come here and try to put dangerous animals out where there are sheep, where there are children, because there's others out there like me who aren't going to stand for it.

Fossil fuel paramilitaries

\- 2025, a video on Rumble..

A Hey everyone, welcome. Shout out to all the subscribers.

There's a link at the bottom to a tip jar, bitcoin or monero. I do these videos myself, every little bit goes straight into keeping the servers on.

Let's get into it and talk about this video from yesterday. Here's what we know: 24 hours ago in Melbourne, a man drives his truck off the road into the sidewalk and he runs down a member of one of the Left parties. The politician's in hospital in critical condition, the driver's been arrested.

First thing I'll say: if that'd been me in that truck, I wouldn't have missed. I wouldn't have clipped her, I would've pasted her to the fucking wall. They would be scraping her off with a spatula.

But on the other hand, we need to be smarter. Why are you running into this woman with a car, son? You could have shot her in the head. You could put a nailbomb through the mailbox of her office and clear out a whole wing of these dirt-worshipping climate cultists.

I'm all for a show of strength, especially when they hold a climate march and their Antifa friends show up. Go ahead and break some fucking heads, sure. But look, we need to be strategic, we need to be tactical.

So I say this every time: if you love your country, if you're willing to fight for your kids' freedom, you should be getting a job in security. Sign up as a security contractor, there are plenty out there hiring. And when you're in, nominate to work at a power station.

The gas plant I work at, we have the place on lock. The whole security team are people I trust - the guys on the switchboard through to the boys at the gates. And there's stations like us all around the country.

Now there will come a day when the shit hits the fan, and the mask comes off. At that point, to the Leftist traitors, I say: we'll see how much power you have when the power goes out.

First fire

I understand you want to fight fire. You want to protect your home, your family, your life. But you have to understand: it's not going to work.

Fire needs life. You can have life without fire - we see that in the oceans - but you can't have fire without life. That's why that there's only one planet in the universe that we know of where fire exists - right here on Earth.

To create fire, you need three things: oxygen, fuel, and a spark.

Free oxygen to burn didn't exist until you had blue-green algae inhaling carbon dioxide and exhaling oxygen into the atmosphere.

Fuel didn't exist until about 400 million years ago, when plants first crept out on land. Once you had dry vegetation, you had something that could burn.

For a long time, the spark was lightning. But about a million years ago, a primate in Africa struck two rocks together and the friction ignited a little clump of dry moss. And from that day on, you became the spark.

Many species have adapted to fire. Some organisms breed in fresh charcoal or forage among ash. Philippine tarsiers grasp embers in their claws. Australian kites carry hot coals in their talons.

But only humans make fire. And fire is what made you human.

Fire provided light and heat. It protected caves and shelters. It made food more edible. It taught you to be caretakers. Fire had to be fed, protected, put to bed, awakened, trained, exercised, bred. It required constant attention and a group to share it.

Without fire, you sink to being a plump chimpanzee with a scraping stone and a digging stick, hiding from the night's terrors.

You are the fire organism. More than any other animal on this earth, you belong to fire.

And now, for the first time in the history of your species, you're trying to fight fire. You're hiding from it, blocking it out, running from it.

But it won't work. If you try to fight fire, it will win. If you run from it, it will find you.

If you want to survive, you need to fall in love with fire again. And that won't be easy.

Shark fin

- It's 2029. The Indian ocean, aboard the Philippines coastguard vessel Panglao.

A It's the hour before dawn. It's pitch black on the water, but in my head I can see the ship in front of us. It's there. It's close. It's not getting away.

90 minutes ago, we got an alert from the tracking agency. They spotted something on the satellites. This little fishing trawler, the F/B Grace Alcarez, crossed into a marine protected area. Could be an accident, could be a navigational error, but they asked us to take a look.

We took a detour and got behind it. When we were close enough, we dropped our little eDNA scanner into the water. The Grace Alcarez has a license to fish bisugo, alumahan, milk fish - but as soon as we dropped the scanner, we started picking up traces of shark DNA.

We didn't even bother radioing them. There's no point. We know what they've been fishing, and they know we know.

When I was a kid, I learned to fish before I learned to walk. My dad used to take me out on the bangka and we'd catch stingrays and coral trout. Every year, there were more and more unlicensed fishing trawlers, and fewer and fewer fish. They hunt with dynamite and blow half the reef to bits to take what they can get. They scrape the sea floor, they hunt protected species, they sell shark fins to China. And we couldn't do anything.

But now at last, we have the technology to track them. We have the resources to chase them. And most of all, we have the will to stop them.

Ahead of us, the little fishing trawler is putting on a burst of speed, but they're not outrunning us. These thieves and all their friends have been stealing from us for so many years, decade upon decade. But not any more.

Tearing up dams

\- 2044, the Pacific Northwest.

A They built the dam, I think, in the early 50s. Mostly for hydropower. Along this stretch there used to be ferns, crayfish, wild foxes, mountain lions. And fish, you used to see big Chinook salmon and steelhead trout flashing in the water. They live in the ocean but they'd swim back up the river to spawn, lay their eggs in the gravel at the bottom of the river.

When they built the dam, it sealed off the whole upper river. They made something called a 'fish ladder' - like a staircase of stepped pools for fish to swim up and over the dam, but it was too steep. We saw the fish struggle to try and climb it, but none of them made it.

Within a couple of years, we saw the fish numbers collapse. 90% vanished, 95% vanished, officially endangered… in 2006, they didn't see a single salmon in the river. They were all gone, completely gone.

Anyway, the last few years, things change. The dam was getting old. You see, rivers normally carry sediment down to the sea, but if you put a dam up, all that sediment gets caught behind the dam wall. Bit by bit, the whole dam was filling up with sludge. The concrete was getting old, and it was no longer safe. That, plus the rise in solar and wind meant the hydropower wasn't as profitable.

So the owners decided to get rid of it. It cost a lot of money, because you can't just blow it up, or all that sediment would just flow out and drown us all in sludge. So they had to carefully remove it, bit at a time, and let the sediment flow out bit by bit. It took longer than they thought, but after two years, the river ran all the way to the sea again.

And as soon as finished - like, within a few weeks - we saw fish in the stream. Just a couple at first, and then more and more. Chinook salmon, steelhead trout. Nearly a century, but they hadn't forgotten. They came back. They came back.

Antarctic seawalls

- 2030, Antarctica.

A We arrive in Antarctica at the beginning of summer. Three months of daylight. It's bright all the time, but cold enough that you can throw a cup of water into the air and see it turn into a cloud of ice crystals before it hits the ground.

There's four hundred of us, from everywhere: Xinjiang, Hebei, Fujian, Beijing, Hainan. Engineers, plumbers, electricians, scientists - even a documentary crew.

The ships arrive carrying six cubic kilometres of rock and gravel, dredged from islands around Australia. They pour it all out into the ocean about 50 metres from shore, on that shallow bit of seafloor called the Jenkins Ridge.

And now our job is to clad all that rock in concrete. To turn this mound of rock and grit into a sea wall. And quickly, before it gets washed away.

Behind us on land is the Pine Island Glacier. From our camp on the shore it looks like a huge hill of ice, but it's a frozen river, with enough water in it to raise the world's oceans by a metre and a half, all by itself.

That river of ice is sliding into the ocean. It's unsticking itself from the rock beneath it and flowing out of this bay, faster and faster every year.

Our job is to stop it happening.

No-one's ever built a wall in the ocean to trap a glacier before. No-one's ever done this scale of undersea construction before, especially not somewhere so remote.

Some people say it can't be done. But if it can't be done, then there goes half the coastal cities in the world. One out of every five human beings on the planet loses their home. So it has to be done.

Some countries say that this is Chinese colonialism, just a ploy to take Antarctica for ourselves. Even Australia, which provided the gravel, says that we're in it for selfish reasons.

Maybe that's true. It's selfish, but I don't want to see Shanghai go underwater. I want my daughters to be able to take their children to Donglin Lu one day.

So we roll up our sleeves and get on with it. It's hard, cold, ugly work. Underwater construction is dangerous at the best of times. Trickier still when you're working around ice shelves which constantly grow and shrink, and wind that picks you off

the ground and throws you sideways.

Lots of frostbite. We all have one or two blackened fingertips. An engineer breaks her leg when a crane collapses. Two divers drown while they're welding a support strut underwater. We never find out for sure what went wrong.

Most people travel home for the winter, but fifty of us stay on to maintain the site. We settle in for a hundred days of darkness, reading comics and watching films.

On the last day of July, there's a huge storm. The winds are up, visibility is zero. We stay indoors for two days.

When we come out, the waves have washed away all the work we did over the summer. The concrete cladding is shattered. The gravel is washed out of the bay. Everything gone. Back to where we started.

So, nothing else for it. We take a deep breath, and we begin again.

Radiant bucks

- 2023, it's an ad on a podcast.

A So you popped the question and they said yes - congratulations. Now comes the hard part: planning your bucks weekend.

In the 2020s, the traditional bucks party is changing. The modern buck wants more than paintball and a piss-up - they want a curated experience that celebrates their masculine energy and helps them prepare for the challenges they'll face in the next phase of their life.

Forget booze and strippers, our elite bucks weekend begins in a custom-designed wave pool, where you and your colleagues will face a simulated severe weather event.

Once your party has 'survived the storm', you'll gather on the deck at sunset for biodynamic champagne, kombucha, and a facilitated conversation about how you can support each other through the escalating climate shocks of the coming decades.

At Radiant Bucks, we know where it's at.

Hair tournament

- 2029, a hairdressing salon.

A I arrived pretty much just as the drought started. Limit your showers, no watering your lawn, all of that. I'd never seen anything like it before.

B None of us had. I mean, a bit when I was growing up, but not like that. The first four years were bad, but then it was scary.

A There were weeks where I had to cut dry hair. We didn't have enough water to properly wash hair.

B You know I got a fine for washing my car? I couldn't believe it. I sprayed it with a hose and scrubbed the dirt off, and one of my neighbours told the police. I was so angry.

A Yeah but you weren't supposed to wash your car.

B I know, I shouldn't have done it, but I just thought - these are my neighbours, narcing me out to the police. Your neighbours are supposed to be your community, you know?

A Isn't that community?

B No! They could have come and talked to me and said, hey, don't do that again. But they never had the guts to talk to me. I still don't know who it was.

A I don't know. You shouldn't tell on people, but at the same time...

B It was my car!

A It was our water!







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